THE COMPLETE VICTORIAN RACEHORSE TRAINING PLAN

Paddock to First Race Back — Targeting 1,200–1,400m Sprint/Middle Distance

Victorian Racing Regulations Compliant | June 2026

> **Disclaimer:** This plan synthesises publicly available information from elite trainers worldwide, peer-reviewed equine sports science, and current Racing Victoria / Racing Australia rules. Always consult a licensed Racing Victoria trainer, veterinarian, and the official Australian Rules of Racing before implementing any program. Regulations are subject to change; verify currency at racingvictoria.com.au and racingaustralia.horse.

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PART 1: VICTORIAN REGULATORY FRAMEWORK

1.1 Governing Bodies

Body	Role
Racing Victoria (RV)	Principal Racing Authority for Victoria
Racing Australia	National rule-making body; publishes Australian Rules of Racing (ARR)
APVMA	Australian Pesticides and Veterinary Medicines Authority — approves equine medications
TGA	Therapeutic Goods Administration — governs therapeutic substances

1.2 Key Rules Every Victorian Trainer Must Know

AR 233(a) — A person must not breach a policy, regulation or code of practice published by Racing Australia or a Principal Racing Authority. This includes the Thoroughbred Racehorse Welfare Policy (TRWP), effective 1 May 2024.

AR 175(h) — Prohibited substance administration offences. Strict liability applies to positive swabs — the trainer is responsible for any prohibited finding regardless of how the substance entered the horse's system.

Thoroughbred Racehorse Welfare Policy (TRWP) — Effective 1 May 2024
- Drafted after consultation with 30+ licensed trainers, RSPCA Victoria, and industry bodies.
- Covers horses' mental and physical health, environment, and end-of-career management.
- Enforceable under AR 233(a) — breaches carry disciplinary consequences.
- Non-compliance identified during property inspections can block or revoke licensing.

1.3 Prohibited Substances (Schedule 1, Australian Rules of Racing)

Absolute Prohibitions (no therapeutic use exemption):
- O-Desmethyltramadol (metabolite of tramadol — opioid analgesic not registered for equine use in Australia)
- Formestane (not registered for animal use by APVMA; not approved by TGA)
- Anabolic steroids not on the permitted therapeutic list
- Beta-2 agonists (prohibited unless on the permitted therapeutic list)
- Any substance in Schedule 1, Part 2, Division 1 (Prohibited List B)

Therapeutic Substances with Screening Limits (Permitted with Withdrawal Compliance):
- Salicylic acid: prohibited at >750 mg/L in urine
- Phenylbutazone, flunixin, meloxicam — permitted therapeutically but require withdrawal observation
- Corticosteroids — permitted with veterinary prescription and mandatory withdrawal
- Omeprazole — permitted with a screening limit; therapeutic doses require withdrawal before racing

Critical Withdrawal Rule:
Intra-articular (joint) injections of any substance are prohibited within **8 clear days** before any race, official trial, or jump-out. This is a Racing Australia Veterinary Advisory Committee requirement adopted into the ARR.

1.4 Medications Permitted on Raceday

- Plain saline IV fluids (for dehydration only)
- Non-medicated electrolyte supplements (no therapeutic agents)
- No products claiming analgesic or anti-inflammatory effects are permitted on raceday — including herbal formulations

1.5 Vaccinations — Victoria-Specific

Vaccine	Status in Victoria	Schedule
Tetanus	Strongly recommended; required by most training centres	Annual booster
Strangles (Strep. equi)	Recommended by Racing Victoria veterinary advisors	Every 6 months
Equine Influenza	NOT available in Australia — disease officially eradicated	N/A (export permit only)
Hendra Virus	Not required in Victoria	Required in QLD/high-risk NSW only
Equine Herpesvirus (EHV-1/4)	Not mandatory; recommended for interstate travel	Every 6 months if travelling

1.6 Swabbing & Sample Collection

- Horses are routinely swabbed post-race (blood and urine)
- Trainer bears full responsibility for any prohibited finding
- Maintain accurate medication records: substance name, dose, date, administering veterinarian
- Racing Victoria stewards can request records at any time

1.7 Trackwork & Trial Regulations (Victoria)

- Track riders must hold current **Mandatory Trackwork Rider Accreditation** (Racing Victoria)
- **Barrier trials** (official): overseen by stewards; cost A$220/horse; distances typically 800–1,000m
- **Jump-outs** (unofficial): run by racing clubs; lower cost; more frequent; good for early education
- Horses must complete at least one satisfactory jump-out or barrier trial before first race start

- Victoria runs approximately one jump-out session per day across the state's racing clubs

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PART 2: ELITE TRAINER PHILOSOPHIES

2.1 Chris Waller (Australia — Sydney/Melbourne)

Australia's premier trainer by career winners. His publicly stated philosophy centres on three pillars: **patience, precision, and genuine care for the horse.** Waller resists commercial pressure to rush horses back from spells, insisting on full physical recovery before escalating workload. His champion sprinter Nature Strip (3× TJ Smith Stakes, 1,200m Group 1) was campaigned with meticulous inter-race management, allowing full muscular and skeletal recovery between starts. Key principles:
- Under-done is always safer than over-done
- Monitor horses' response to work daily — not just on gallop days
- Horse behaviour and appetite are performance indicators as important as the watch

2.2 Gai Waterhouse (Australia — Sydney)

Eight Golden Slipper Stakes wins including Lady of Camelot (2024). Known for:
- Sharp, high-energy speed work for sprinters — developing explosive capacity early in preparation
- Use of swimming pools and water treadmills as supplementary conditioning tools
- Breeding-informed training: understanding how much speed vs. conditioning work suits each horse's genetic profile
- Regular pre-race gallops at near-race pace over 600–800m within the final week

2.3 John Sadler (Victoria — Pakenham Training Complex)

40+ years as a licensed trainer. Notable publicly disclosed attributes:
- Trains up to 30 horses at Pakenham — one of Victoria's best modern facilities
- Four years in Dubai in the early 2000s: adopted international techniques for heat management, electrolyte protocols, and conditioning in demanding climates
- Hands-on daily trainer — personal leg examination before and after every work session is non-negotiable
- Strategic race placement: does not rush to race; targets conditions races and lower grades first to build confidence before stepping up in class

2.4 Danny O'Brien (Victoria — Flemington + Barwon Heads)

Flemington base with a 160-acre private training complex at Barwon Heads:
- Private property allows extended paddock access and slow conditioning on grass — vital for tendon and mental health
- Known for strategic placement — maximising confidence and race experience at the right level

- Strong barrier manners emphasis: for 1,200–1,400m races, a poor gate exit can cost 3–4 lengths immediately

2.5 Godolphin (Global — Newmarket / Dubai / Sydney / Melbourne)

World's largest racing operation (trainers Saeed bin Suroor, Charlie Appleby):
- Yearlings undergo full acclimatisation before any serious training begins
- Combination of groundwork, swimming, schooling, and light riding before full-scale work
- State-of-the-art facilities: private grass and all-weather gallops, swimming pools, equine spas
- Meticulous monitoring: trainers, jockeys, and stable staff all report daily observations on each horse
- Philosophy: mental and physical readiness must align — horses are never pushed into training before they are prepared in both dimensions

2.6 Aidan O'Brien (Ireland — Ballydoyle)

Globally the most successful trainer of Group 1 winners:
- Prepares both early-speed two-year-old sprinters and long-distance stayers with the same fundamental patience
- Builds an enormous aerobic base first, then adds speed work closer to the racing campaign
- Extensive use of authentic grass gallops at Ballydoyle
- Group exercise (horses canter together in strings) is central to mental conditioning and social development

2.7 Japan Racing Association (JRA) — Ritto & Miho Training Centres

Japan's state-regulated, highly systematic approach:
- Two major centres (Ritto, Shiga; Miho, Ibaraki) — each housing 2,000+ horses
- Horse must train at a JRA facility for a **minimum of 15 days** before debut
- All horses must pass a **starting gate examination** before their first race — no gate clearance, no race
- Facilities include: 6 track-style training courses, an uphill course (>1km), horse swimming pool, strolling promenades, horse clinic
- Systematic, graduated workload with documented daily logs for every horse
- Japanese trainers' uphill conditioning track is recognised internationally as a major contributor to Japan's outstanding preparation for middle distances

2.8 Universal Principles Across All Elite Trainers

1. **Patience over speed** — every elite trainer resists rushing horses back to race
2. **Daily observation** — legs, demeanour, appetite, and attitude assessed every single day
3. **Progressive overload** — workload increases gradually across weeks, never days
4. **Mental readiness = physical readiness** — an anxious horse cannot perform at its physical ceiling

5. **Recovery IS training** — physiological adaptation happens during rest, not during work
6. **Individual programs** — no two horses train identically; the program must fit the horse

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PART 3: THE COMPLETE PHASE-BY-PHASE TRAINING PLAN

Overview Timeline

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 SPELL          PRE-TRAINING      BASE FITNESS      RACE PREP        TRIAL/RACE
[4–8 wks]      [Weeks 1–4]       [Weeks 5–8]       [Weeks 9–12]     [Weeks 13–16]
    |               |                 |                 |                 |
Paddock         Walk/trot         Half pace         3/4 pace          Barrier trial
Grazing         Slow canter       Build tendons     Full gallops      Jump-out
Social time     Leg foundation    Introduce speed   1200m pieces      FIRST RACE
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Total program: 14–16 weeks from paddock to first race
(A trouble-free, sound, experienced horse can be race-ready in 10–12 weeks minimum; first-timers or horses returning from injury require the full 14–16 weeks.)

PHASE 1: SPELLING / PADDOCK PHASE (4–8 Weeks)

Purpose: Physical and mental recovery. Bone remodelling, tendon and ligament repair, muscle restoration, and psychological reset.

Spell Duration Guidelines:
- After a light 2–3 race campaign: 4–6 weeks minimum
- After a long campaign (6+ starts): 8–12 weeks
- After injury: as directed by veterinarian; typically 3–6+ months depending on type
- Young horses after breaking-in / first prep: 4–6 weeks letting down

Daily Spell Routine:

Time	Activity
Dawn	Turn out to paddock — free grazing
Throughout day	Unrestricted paddock access; social interaction with other horses where safe
Morning	Quick visual health check: legs, eyes, coat, body condition score
Afternoon	Handle and groom; check hooves daily
Dusk	Return to stable if stabled overnight; hay and water maintained

Key Management Points:
- **Body condition score (BCS) target:** 5/9 on Henneke scale — a slightly lean horse is far easier to bring back into work than an overweight one
- **Social grazing:** Spell horses in groups or adjacent paddocks where safe — isolation

elevates cortisol, impairing recovery
- **Gradual let-down:** Reduce hard feed over 5–7 days in the first week; do not abruptly stop grain feeding (gut microbiome requires time to adjust)
- **Shoes removed** during paddock rest to allow natural hoof expansion and circulation; farrier visit every 5–6 weeks for trimming
- **Weekly weigh-tape** measurements to track body condition trend

Veterinary During Spell:
- Full veterinary examination at start of spell — identify any issues requiring treatment
- Any intra-articular injections administered here must be timed so the 8-clear-day rule is satisfied before the next race (plan the return date accordingly)
- Dental check if >12 months since last float
- Fecal egg count (FEC) before any worming decision

Feed During Spell:
- Primarily pasture grazing
- Good quality oaten or meadow hay ad lib (~1.5–2% body weight in dry matter/day)
- Gradually reduce and then eliminate hard grain feed by end of Week 1
- Maintain basic vitamin/mineral supplement
- Fresh water unrestricted (horses require minimum 20–30L/day)

PHASE 2: PRE-TRAINING — SLOW WORK FOUNDATION (Weeks 1–4)

Purpose: Rebuild tendons, ligaments, and bone density. Reactivate cardiovascular system. Re-establish muscle mass. Re-engage mental focus.

Critical Science Note: Tendons and ligaments adapt to training load approximately 10× slower than cardiovascular fitness or muscle mass. This phase cannot be compressed — doing so is the leading cause of soft-tissue injury in thoroughbreds returning from spell.

Weeks 1–2: Walk & Slow Trot

Day	Morning Session	Afternoon
Mon	20-min walk on track or sand	Paddock turnout 1–2 hrs
Tue	25-min walk + 5-min trot	Rest / turnout
Wed	REST — paddock turnout only	—
Thu	30-min walk + 10-min trot	Turnout
Fri	30-min walk + 10-min trot	Turnout
Sat	35-min walk + 15-min trot	Turnout
Sun	REST	Paddock turnout

- Walk speed: ~1.4 m/s; Trot: ~3.5–4.5 m/s
- Total weekly distance: ~6,000–8,000m
- Use sand track or soft grass to minimise concussion on healing structures
- Mechanical walker can supplement 20–30 min/day

Weeks 3–4: Introduce Slow Canter

Day	Morning Session	Notes
Mon	30-min warm-up walk/trot + 1× 600m slow canter	Relaxed, rhythmic — no rushing
Tue	40-min walk/trot — recovery	Active recovery only
Wed	REST or 20-min walk	Check legs post-Monday canter
Thu	30-min walk/trot + 1× 800m slow canter	Extend canter slightly
Fri	40-min walk/trot	Recovery
Sat	30-min walk/trot + 1× 1,000m slow canter	Further extension
Sun	REST	Paddock turnout

- Slow canter: ~5–7 m/s (18–25 km/h) — what Australian trainers call a "trot canter" or "slow pace"
- Total weekly distance: ~10,000–12,000m
- **Mandatory pre- and post-work leg check after every canter session** — run hands over all four legs; any heat or swelling means reduce workload immediately and call the vet

Feed Adjustment in Phase 2:
- Week 1: Reintroduce 500g–1kg oats per feed (morning post-work + evening)
- Week 2–3: Increase to 1.5–2 kg oats per feed
- Week 4 target: 2–3 kg oats/feed × 2 daily feeds = 4–6 kg oats/day
- Continue hay ad lib + chaff mixed into feed

PHASE 3: BASE FITNESS BUILDING (Weeks 5–8)

Purpose: Build aerobic base, strengthen musculoskeletal system, introduce half-pace work, begin barrier education and mental conditioning for race environments.

Training Speed Reference (Australian Standard):
- Half pace: ~11 m/s (~40 km/h) = approximately 18 seconds per 200m
- Three-quarter pace: ~13–14 m/s (~47–50 km/h) = approximately 14–15 seconds per 200m
- Full gallop (race pace): ~16–17 m/s (~58–61 km/h) = approximately 12 seconds per 200m

Weeks 5–6: Extending Canter + First Half-Pace Work

Day	Work	Notes
Mon	1,000m warm-up canter + 1,000m half pace	First half-pace piece — keep relaxed
Tue	40-min slow recovery canter	Active recovery
Wed	REST or 20-min walk	Legs checked carefully
Thu	1,000m warm-up + 1,200m half pace	Extend half pace
Fri	Slow canter 1,500m	Light work
Sat	1,000m canter + 1,200m half pace + 200m brush (faster finish)	First "brush" — short fast piece at end
Sun	REST + paddock	—

- Total fast work: ~1,200–1,400m per session, twice weekly
- Monthly total: targeting ~8,000–12,000m of combined canter/pace work
- This sits within the "medium-volume" workload cluster identified in Victorian racing research (Morrice-West 2020)

Weeks 7–8: Three-Quarter Pace Introduction

Day	Work	Notes
Mon	1,000m canter + 1,200m three-quarter pace	¾ pace = ~13–14 m/s / 14–15s per 200m
Tue	Recovery canter 1,500–2,000m	Steady rhythm only
Wed	REST or mechanical walker 30 min	Full leg check
Thu	1,000m canter + 1,000m ¾ pace + 200m stride out	Stride out = faster than ¾ but not full race pace
Fri	Recovery canter	—
Sat	1,000m canter + 800m ¾ pace + 400m near-gallop	Building toward true gallop fitness
Sun	REST	—

Begin Barrier Training — Week 6 or 7
Parallel to trackwork:
- Week 6: Walk horse through stationary barrier stalls; reward calm behaviour
- Week 7: Load, stand quietly in gate, walk out
- Week 8: Load, hold briefly, trot out through gate
- Target: horse loading calmly and standing without resistance before any official trial
- Victoria: stewards assess gate behaviour at barrier trials — horses that consistently act up can be stood down pending further schooling

Mental Conditioning During Phase 3:
- Introduce horses to busy track environments on non-gallop days
- Vary training route — new environments build adaptability
- Use experienced lead/companion horses alongside anxious individuals

PHASE 4: RACE PREPARATION — GALLOP CONDITIONING (Weeks 9–12)

Purpose: Develop race-specific cardiovascular and muscular capacity. Build anaerobic fitness. Establish race-pace speed memory. Finalise barrier manners.

Science Background:
- High-speed conditioning improves Type II (fast-twitch) muscle fibre function — the primary energy system for 1,200–1,400m sprint/middle distances
- Target training intensity: 75–85% of maximum race speed (breezing)
- Do NOT train regularly at 95–100% maximum speed — leads to overtraining and injury
- Most Victorian trainers gallop twice per week; high-intensity work is separated by at least 48–72 hours of active recovery
- After every high-intensity session, 48–72 hours of light/active recovery before the next fast work

Weeks 9–10: Full Gallop Introduction

Day	Work	Speed
Mon	1,000m canter + 600m ¾ pace + 400m full gallop	Gallop = ~12–13s/200m
Tue	Slow recovery canter 2,000m	5–7 m/s only
Wed	REST or 30-min walker	Full leg check
Thu	1,000m canter + 600m ¾ pace + 400m gallop	Maintain momentum throughout
Fri	Slow recovery canter	—
Sat	1,000m canter + ¾ pace + 600–800m gallop	Key weekly conditioning session
Sun	REST	Paddock turnout

- Saturday long gallop is the key conditioning session each week
- Classic "5+2" (5 furlongs canter + 2 furlongs gallop) = 1,000m + 400m = ideal for 1,200m conditioning
- Increase gallop distance weekly by ~200m

Weeks 11–12: Race-Distance Conditioning

Day	Work	Notes
Mon	1,000m canter + 1,000m ¾ pace + 400m gallop	Classic "strong half"
Tue	2,000m slow recovery canter	Recovery
Wed	REST + physiotherapy session if available	—
Thu	1,000m canter + 600m ¾ pace + 800m gallop	Building gallop distance
Fri	Recovery canter 1,500m	Light
Sat	1,000m canter + 1,200m combined ¾ pace/gallop	Reaching toward race distance
Sun	REST	Paddock turnout

Sprint/Middle Distance Specifics for 1,200–1,400m:
- Peak conditioning gallop for a **1,200m horse**: 1,000–1,200m at ¾ pace transitioning to race pace in the final 400m
- Peak conditioning gallop for a **1,400m horse**: 1,200–1,400m at sustained ¾ pace, last 400m at full gallop
- Do not routinely gallop horses farther than the race distance — specific adaptation is the goal
- The "5+4" work (1,000m slow + 800m gallop) is the classic conditioning set used by most Australian trainers for 1,200m horses

Interval Training (Advanced — Optional from Week 10):
Used by ~30% of top trainers for maximal cardiovascular development:
- 2–3 × 600m at ¾ pace with 5-minute walking recovery between reps
- Builds aerobic base and lactate clearance capacity
- Scientific research confirms interval training improves aerobic capacity and may alter muscle fibre recruitment compared to single-long-work methods
- Only introduce once horse comfortably handles the standard single gallop
- Never use interval training within 7 days of a race or barrier trial

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PHASE 5: FINAL PREPARATION & BARRIER TRIALS (Weeks 12–14)

Purpose: Sharpen fitness, confirm race readiness, complete barrier trial formality, allow freshening before race debut.

Weeks 12–13: Pre-Trial Sharpening

Day	Work	Notes
Mon	1,000m canter + 600m ¾ pace + 400m full gallop	"Sharp and short"
Tue	Recovery canter 1,500m	—
Wed	REST	Pre-trial mental freshening
Thu	1,000m canter + 400m ¾ pace + 600m race-pace gallop	Pre-trial conditioning gallop
Fri	Recovery 1,000m canter	—
Sat	BARRIER TRIAL (800–1,000m)	Honest run — not over-extended
Sun	REST + careful leg observation	Check legs thoroughly post-trial

Barrier Trial Protocol:
- Book 5–7 days in advance through Racing Victoria's system
- Ensure current vaccination records are available for racecourse club requirements
- Confirm track rider has current Mandatory Trackwork Rider Accreditation
- Cost: A$220/horse (official trial); jump-outs are cheaper and more frequent — excellent for initial settling
- Recommended sequence: 1–2 jump-outs → 1–2 official barrier trials → first race
- Stewards observe and assess gate behaviour, racing manners, and overall soundness

- JRA best-practice principle applied: if gate behaviour is not satisfactory, do additional schooling before proceeding to official trial

Week 14: Final Pre-Race Preparation

Day	Work	Notes
Mon	1,000m canter + 400m ¾ pace + 400m sharp gallop	"Put an edge on"
Tue	Recovery canter 1,200m	Light
Wed	REST	—
Thu	1,000m canter + 400m sharp half-pace brush	FINAL WORK for Saturday race
Fri	Travel or stable rest	Legs checked twice; normal feed maintained
Sat	RACE DAY	See Part 9

Key Timing Rule:
Final gallop should be completed **no later than 48 hours before race time**. Most experienced Victorian trainers complete final work Thursday morning for a Saturday race — this allows adequate muscular recovery while maintaining race sharpness.

PART 4: NUTRITION & FEEDING PROGRAM

4.1 Foundation Principles

1. **Forage first** — a thoroughbred's digestive system evolved for continuous high-fibre forage intake; concentrates supplement, not replace, forage
2. **Grain timing** — grain meals must be given **minimum 4 hours before exercise** to optimise glycogen availability and prevent digestive disruption during work
3. **Small, frequent meals** — horses have relatively small stomachs; 2–3 grain feeds/day rather than one large meal
4. **60:40 rule** — during peak training: 60–70% of diet weight as hard feed (grain + chaff), 30–40% as hay; during spell: reverse to ~30% hard / 70% forage
5. **Calcium:Phosphorus balance** — grain is high in phosphorus, low in calcium; lucerne hay is high in calcium — feed together to naturally balance Ca:P ratio (target 2:1)

4.2 Hay Types

Hay Type	Properties	When to Feed	Approximate Rate
Lucerne (Alfalfa)	High protein (18–22%), high calcium, high energy	Year-round; primary hay for horses in training	3–5 kg/day
Oaten Hay	Moderate energy, lower protein, high fibre, palatable	Spelling horses; mix with lucerne to moderate protein	2–4 kg/day
Wheaten Chaff	High fibre; adds bulk to hard feed; slows gut transit	Mixed into grain feed daily	0.5–1 kg per feed
Lucerne Chaff	Higher protein and calcium; improves palatability	Mixed with wheaten chaff in feed	0.3–0.5 kg per feed
Meadow/ Grass Hay	Lower energy, high fibre	During spell phase	Ad lib during spell

4.3 Hard Feed (Concentrates)

Feed	Properties	Recommended Rate	Notes
Whole Oats	Primary energy source; well-tolerated; NSC ~50%	Up to 5 kg/day split across 2 feeds	Introduce gradually; adjust per individual horse
Rolled Barley	"Cooler" energy — lower glycaemic index than oats; conditioning feed	Replace oats at 1:0.9 ratio (1 kg oats = 900g barley)	Excellent for horses prone to tying-up or excitable behaviour
Stabilised Rice Bran	High fat (18–22%); body and coat conditioner	0.5–1 kg/day	Use calcium-supplemented varieties to balance high phosphorus
Commercial Racehorse Pellets	Pre-balanced concentrate with vitamins and minerals	As per manufacturer label (typically 2–4 kg/ day)	Mitavite Racehorse, Hygain Racehorse, and Barastoc Racehorse are widely used in Victoria
Micronised/ Extruded Corn	Very high energy	Use sparingly — <1 kg/ day	High glycaemic load; risk of digestive upset if overfed

4.4 Feeding Program by Training Phase

Spelling Phase:
- Morning: 1–2 kg lucerne hay + small chaff + vitamin/mineral supplement
- Evening: 2–3 kg oaten or meadow hay
- Hard feed: Gradually reduced to zero by end of Week 1 of spell
- Water: Unlimited fresh supply at all times

Pre-Training (Weeks 1–4):
- Pre-work (morning): Chaff only — 0.5–1 kg wheaten + 0.3 kg lucerne chaff; no grain before first light work

- Post-work (morning): 1–2 kg oats + chaff mix + vitamin/mineral supplement
- Evening: 2–3 kg oats + chaff + 2 kg lucerne hay
- Total oats: Building from 1 kg/day (Week 1) to 3–4 kg/day (Week 4)
- Ensure minimum 4-hour gap between any grain meal and exercise

Base Fitness (Weeks 5–8):
- Pre-work (1–1.5 hours before): Chaff only — 1 kg + small soaked hay
- Post-work: 2–2.5 kg oats + chaff + 1 kg stabilised rice bran if conditioning needed
- Evening: 2.5–3 kg oats + chaff + 2 kg lucerne hay
- Total oats: 4–5 kg/day divided across two feeds

Race Preparation (Weeks 9–14):
- Pre-work: Chaff only — 1 kg; no grain within 4 hours of gallop work
- Post-work: 2–3 kg oats + chaff + vitamin/mineral supplement
- Evening: 2.5–3 kg oats + chaff + 2 kg lucerne hay + electrolytes 2–3×/week
- Total oats: 5–6 kg/day (maximum for most horses; adjust to individual body condition)
- On rest days: reduce grain by 30–50% — a horse doing no work should not receive a full training ration

4.5 Supplements

Supplement	Purpose	Scientific Basis	When to Use
Electrolytes (Na, Cl, K, Mg, Ca)	Replace sweat losses; prevent dehydration and tying-up	Racehorses lose multiple litres of sweat per session; electrolyte imbalance impairs muscle contraction and increases tying-up risk	2–3× per week during training; mandatory post-race
Vitamin E	Antioxidant; muscle cell protection; immune function	Exercise generates free radicals and oxidative stress; Vitamin E is the primary fat-soluble antioxidant neutralising these	Daily during training (1,000–3,000 IU/day for horses in hard work)
Selenium	Antioxidant (synergistic with Vit E); thyroid function; muscle integrity	Australian soils are selenium-deficient across many regions; deficiency causes nutritional myopathy	As directed by veterinarian — toxicity is possible above 3mg/day total from all sources
CoQ10 (Coenzyme Q10)	Mitochondrial energy production; ATP synthesis	Thoroughbred research shows significant plasma CoQ10 decrease following high-intensity exercise; supplementation improves ATP production adaptations	During peak training and racing campaigns
B Vitamins (B1, B2, B12)	Energy metabolism; nervous system; red blood cell production	B12 supports RBC production (critical for oxygen-carrying capacity); B1 supports calm temperament	Daily during training; especially valuable for horses that go off feed under stress or travel
Magnesium	Muscle relaxation; nerve function; mild calming effect	Deficiency causes muscle cramps and increases tying-up risk; legitimate calming effect for excitable horses (not prohibited)	Daily in training; increase around work and race days
Joint supplements (Glucosamine, Chondroitin, MSM)	Cartilage health; joint fluid viscosity; anti-inflammatory support	Long-term evidence supports reduced cartilage breakdown in horses under sustained training loads	From 3-year-old onwards; daily during training campaigns
Omega-3 fatty acids	Anti-inflammatory; lung health; coat condition	Anti-inflammatory effect on respiratory airways — important for horses with mild EIPH or subclinical RAO	Daily; ground flaxseed (linseed) or stabilised fish oil

Victorian Compliance Note on Supplements:
All supplements must either hold APVMA registration or be exempt from registration under Australian law. Request a written declaration from the manufacturer confirming the product contains no substances prohibited under the ARR Schedule 1. The trainer bears full responsibility for any prohibited finding regardless of source.

PART 5: RECOVERY PROTOCOLS

5.1 Immediate Post-Work Recovery (After Every Gallop Session)

Step 1 — Cool-Down Walk (15–20 minutes)
Walk on a loose rein or in hand immediately after work. Do not return to stable at pace. Target: respiratory rate below 30 breaths/minute before stabling.

Step 2 — Cold Water Hosing (10–15 minutes)
Hose all four legs and body with cold water after cool-down walk. Focus on lower limbs, tendons, and fetlock joints. The water pressure provides mild massage action, aiding lymphatic circulation and reducing distal limb oedema. Hand-dry legs after hosing and observe for new heat or swelling.

Step 3 — Ice Boots or Cold Water Immersion (20–30 minutes)
After complete cool-down, apply ice boots or stand horse in buckets of ice water up to the knee. Optimal duration: 20–30 minutes for meaningful tendon temperature reduction. Used routinely by most elite Australian trainers after every gallop. High-tech options (compression + sustained cold therapy machines) are used at Godolphin and large operations.

Step 4 — Leg Check and Stable Bandages
After ice treatment, palpate all four legs for heat, filling, or pain response. Apply stable bandages over gamgee/cotton wool for overnight support. New heat or swelling = veterinarian consult before next work session.

Step 5 — Rehydration and Post-Work Feed
Offer water immediately on return to stable (horses may drink 10–20L after hard work). Add electrolytes to post-work water or feed on gallop days. Feed post-work grain meal 30–60 minutes after returning to stable (gut motility has returned to normal by then).

5.2 Swimming

Used by 60% of leading Australian trainers (documented in survey of 270 Australian Standardbred trainers; similar prevalence in thoroughbred training across Victoria and NSW):
- **Primary benefit:** Maximum cardiovascular stimulus with zero concussive load on limbs
- **Session duration:** 3–5 minutes continuous swimming equals a significant cardiovascular load
- **Best use:** 2–3 sessions/week during base fitness phase as supplementary conditioning; replaces trackwork when a horse has a minor limb issue requiring reduced concussion
- **Limitation:** Swimming positions the horse head-high — unlike race posture. Use as a complement to trackwork rather than a complete substitute.

5.3 Water Treadmill (Underwater Treadmill)

- Combines buoyancy (reduces concussive loading by 40–60%) with resistive exercise
- Research confirms thoroughbreds rehabbed on underwater treadmill after carpal or fetlock chip surgery returned to racing **earlier** than horses rehabbed on dry treadmill

- Ideal for: horses recovering from tendon/ligament strain, mild arthritis, post-surgical recovery, general deconditioning
- Proactive use: builds hindquarter and core strength during base fitness phase
- Typical program: 20–30 minutes at walk/trot, water level at chest height

5.4 Rest Day Management

- Minimum 1 full rest day per week (Sunday is standard across most Victorian stables)
- Paddock turnout on rest days — essential for psychological wellbeing (grazing and movement reduce stress hormones)
- Mechanical walker: 20–30 min on rest days maintains joint lubrication and circulation without taxing the musculoskeletal system
- Never stable a horse for extended periods without any form of movement

5.5 Physiotherapy and Soft-Tissue Therapy

- **Equine massage:** 1–2 sessions/week during race prep phase by a qualified equine physiotherapist. Focus: gluteal muscles, hamstrings, longissimus dorsi (back), shoulder muscles. Releases tightness that reduces stride length and speed.
- **Low-level laser therapy (LLLT):** Used at major operations for tendon and ligament rehabilitation.
- **PEMF (Pulsed Electromagnetic Field Therapy):** Godolphin and other elite stables use PEMF for anti-inflammatory and tissue repair support.
- **Chiropractic/osteopathic care:** Spinal alignment assessed every 6–8 weeks. Subluxations reduce hindquarter engagement and alter gait efficiency.

PART 6: VETERINARY & HEALTH MANAGEMENT

6.1 Pre-Training Veterinary Protocol (Start of Every New Preparation)

- Full physical examination including cardiovascular auscultation
- Endoscopy (upper airway scope): check for DDSP (palate displacement), epiglottic entrapment, or arytenoid asymmetry
- Gastroscopy if horse has history of poor appetite, reluctance to work, or weight loss — equine gastric ulcer syndrome (EGUS) affects up to 90% of horses in training
- Radiograph any joints of previous concern
- Blood panel: full CBC, serum biochemistry, selenium, vitamin E levels
- Fecal egg count (FEC) before any worming decision

6.2 Vaccination Schedule (Victoria)

Vaccine	Primary Course	Booster	Victorian Requirement
Tetanus	2 doses 4–6 weeks apart; single booster if unvaccinated adult	Annual	Strongly recommended; required at most training centres
Strangles	2 doses 4 weeks apart	Every 6 months	Recommended by RV veterinary advisors
Equine Herpesvirus (EHV-1/4)	2 doses per product label	Every 6 months for travellers	Not mandatory in Victoria; recommended for interstate travel
Equine Influenza	Not available in Australia	N/A	Disease eradicated in Australia; vaccine not licensed except for export
Hendra Virus	Per product label	Annual in risk zones	Not required in Victoria; required in Queensland

Maintain a written vaccination log: date, product name, batch number, administering veterinarian.

6.3 Dental Care

Horse Age	Exam Frequency	Key Issues
2–5 years	Every 6 months	Permanent teeth erupting; wolf tooth removal; sharp enamel points
5–15 years	Annually	Sharp points; irregular wear
15+ years	Every 6 months	Progressive dental disease; weight loss risk

Wolf teeth (vestigial premolars) should be removed before breaking-in if present — bit-related pain causes resistance and behavioural problems. Signs of dental pain: head-shaking, difficulty with contact, dropping feed (quidding).

6.4 Parasite Control (Targeted Selective Treatment)

Racing Victoria and equine bodies recommend **Targeted Selective Treatment (TST)** over calendar-based rotation:

Step	Action	Frequency
1	Fecal egg count (FEC)	Before each potential treatment
2	Treat only if egg count >200–500 EPG	As needed, not on a fixed schedule
3	Egg count reduction test 14 days post-treatment	Every treatment to check efficacy
4	Annual bot treatment (ivermectin)	Autumn/winter after bot fly season
5	Annual tapeworm treatment (double-dose pyrantel or praziquantel)	As part of annual program

Do not administer ivermectin within 2 weeks of a major high-intensity work session — some horses show mild dullness post-treatment.

6.5 Hoof Care

Service	Frequency	Type
Farrier — training	Every 3–5 weeks	Steel plates for trackwork; aluminium racing plates for race day
Farrier — race day	Day before or morning of race	Lightweight aluminium plates (minimise weight)
Hoof pads	As needed	For solar bruising or thin soles
Hoof oil/ dressing	Daily if hooves are dry or brittle	Keratex or farrier-recommended product

All Victorian major tracks are grass — aluminium plates are standard for racing. Ensure clips (toe or side) are fitted to suit individual hoof conformation.

6.6 Gastric Ulcer (EGUS) Prevention

Prevention is far more effective and cheaper than treatment:
- Provide a small amount of hay (1–2 kg) before morning exercise — buffers stomach acid during work
- Never allow >6-hour gaps without access to forage
- Maximise paddock turnout and reduce stall confinement
- Omeprazole (Gastrogard/Ulcerguard): prophylactic low-dose use during high-stress periods (new stable, heavy campaign, travel) is common under veterinary supervision
- Omeprazole has a screening limit under ARR — observe withdrawal times before racing; consult current schedule

6.7 Exertional Rhabdomyolysis ("Tying Up") Prevention

Particularly common in fillies and excitable horses:
- Never suddenly increase grain without a corresponding increase in workload
- Maintain consistent work schedule — irregular work combined with full feeding is the

primary trigger
- Switch to rolled barley from oats for prone horses (lower glycaemic index)
- Supplement vitamin E, selenium, and magnesium
- Reduce grain by 30–50% on rest days

PART 7: MENTAL CONDITIONING & PSYCHOLOGY

7.1 Foundation Principles

Thoroughbreds are prey animals — their default response to unfamiliar stimuli is fear and flight. Racing conditions (crowd noise, barrier stalls, other horses, jockeys, race gear) are inherently unnatural. Mental conditioning must run parallel to physical conditioning. A horse that is anxious cannot perform at its physical ceiling.

7.2 Phase-by-Phase Mental Program

Spelling Phase:
- Paddock with other horses: herd socialisation naturally reduces cortisol levels
- Minimal human pressure: allow the horse to recover psychologically
- Regular gentle handling to maintain trust, leading, and halter manners

Pre-Training (Weeks 1–4):
- Consistent daily routine: same feed times, same handler, same training path
- Gradually introduce new equipment: racing saddle, racing bridle, lead ponies
- Positive reinforcement: reward calm behaviour; never punish fear responses aggressively — this creates conditioned fear responses that are very difficult to reverse

Base Fitness (Weeks 5–8):
- Introduce barrier education (see Phase 3 barrier protocol above)
- Expose horse to track environments on non-gallop days: walk past spectator areas, around parade ring
- Work in pairs or small groups — horses are dramatically calmer alongside companions
- Introduce any race-day gear (blinkers, tongue tie, shadow roll) during daily training — never introduce unfamiliar equipment for the first time on race day

Race Preparation (Weeks 9–12):
- Barrier practice 2–3 times per week
- Practice: calm loading, standing quietly, hearing the bell, breaking cleanly
- Use quiet, experienced lead horses during barrier sessions
- Paddock access on rest days remains important for mental reset throughout this period

Pre-Race (Weeks 13–14):
- Keep routine identical to established training routine — changes in routine directly increase anxiety
- Where possible, take horse to the racecourse as a "tourist" before race day: paddock walkthrough, familiarisation with the mounting yard and grandstand noise

- Brief track rider and jockey thoroughly — a calm, confident rider transmits that confidence directly to the horse

7.3 Managing Anxiety Signs

Signs requiring attention:
- Excessive sweating before work begins
- Inability to settle at the canter
- Weaving or box-walking (stable vices / stereotypies)
- Loss of appetite
- Reluctance to load in barriers

Management options:
- Do not increase workload when a horse is acutely anxious — address the psychological issue first
- Magnesium supplementation has a genuine calming effect and is **not prohibited** under ARR
- **Critical caution:** Many marketed "calming" products contain valerian or reserpine — both are listed as **prohibited substances** under the ARR. Check every product against the current schedule before use.

PART 8: TECHNOLOGY & FITNESS MONITORING

8.1 Heart Rate Monitoring

Modern professional stables increasingly use GPS + heart rate systems (e.g., Arioneo Equimetre, widely used in Australia):

Metric	What It Tells You	Normal Range
Maximum Heart Rate (HRmax)	Overall cardiovascular capacity	204–241 BPM (thoroughbred normal range)
V200 (speed at HR 200 bpm)	Proxy for VO2max / aerobic fitness level	Higher = better aerobic fitness; tracks improvement across prep
Heart Rate Recovery	Speed of return to resting HR post-work	Fitter horses recover measurably faster
GPS Speed Data	Actual speed at each point of gallop	Cross-reference with trainer's intended split times

As fitness develops through the program, V200 increases — this provides objective, measurable evidence of cardiovascular adaptation independent of subjective assessment.

8.2 Standardised Fitness Test Protocol (Treadmill)

If access to a high-speed treadmill is available (University of Melbourne Veterinary Hospital, Werribee, or major training centre equine hospitals):

Standard incremental test:
1. 3 minutes at 4 m/s
2. 90 seconds at 6 m/s
3. 60-second intervals at 8, 10, 11, 12, 13 m/s
4. Treadmill incline: 6 degrees
5. Measure: HR at each speed; blood lactate; VO2 if available

Conduct at: start of prep (baseline), Week 6–7 (mid-prep), Week 12–13 (pre-race peak) to track the fitness curve and confirm the horse is developing on schedule.

8.3 Stride Analysis

Research shows that peak stride length and frequency during training correlates directly with race outcomes in thoroughbreds. For 1,200–1,400m horses:
- Success comes from a combination of high stride frequency AND adequate stride length
- Tracking stride data identifies whether the horse is naturally a "leg speed" type or a "strider" — this informs optimal distance selection and race placement strategy

8.4 Daily Training Log (Required Under TRWP Best Practice)

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Date | Horse | Work Type | Distance (m) | Time/Speed | Rider | Legs Pre | Legs Post | Notes
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Enables early identification of overtraining (progressive performance decline without program change) and satisfies TRWP documentation expectations. Also provides evidentiary support if a stewards inquiry arises regarding training activities.

PART 9: RACE-DAY PROTOCOL

9.1 Pre-Race Week

T–7 days:
- Reduce total training volume 20–30% (taper begins while maintaining intensity)
- Confirm race entry, expected barrier draw, jockey booking
- Check vaccination records are current for the race club's requirements
- Ensure all race gear is ready: racing plates, race bridle, blinkers/tongue tie if used

T–4 days:
- Final conditioning gallop (light — 1,000m canter + 400m half-pace brush)
- Begin electrolyte loading: twice daily in feed for 3 days pre-race
- Confirm horse is bright, eating well, and all four legs are clean

T–2 days (Thursday for Saturday race):
- Light canter only: 1,000–1,500m slow
- Final sharpening piece completed by now
- Confirm transport, stable bookings at racecourse

T–1 day (Friday):
- Rest: stable rest or 20-min hand walk only
- Afternoon: ice boots 20–30 minutes
- Feed as normal; hay access maintained overnight
- Check racing plates — replace if worn
- Pack race equipment bag

9.2 Race Day — Hour by Hour

Pre-Dawn:
- 4:00–5:00am: Feed chaff only — no grain within 4 hours of race time
- Hay access maintained overnight (prevents overnight acid damage)

Morning:
- Full four-leg palpation check — any heat or filling: contact veterinarian immediately
- Light grooming; confirm shoes are secure
- Apply ice boots 20–30 minutes (1.5–2 hours before travel)
- Small electrolyte dose in water

Arrival at Racecourse (2–3 hours before race):
- Allow horse to settle in racecourse stables
- Offer small high-fibre feed (chaff or hay only — no grain at the course)
- Fresh water available at all times
- In-hand walk around mounting yard/parade ring to familiarise and settle
- Horse must pass pre-race veterinary inspection by the racecourse veterinarian

Pre-Race (40–60 minutes before post time):
- Saddle horse; apply all declared gear (blinkers, tongue tie, etc.)
- Jockey receives trainer's race instructions
- Anti-sweat sheet or rug in cold weather
- Parade ring warm-up; gentle exposure to crowd noise

Post-Race (Immediate):
- Walk horse minimum 15–20 minutes — never return to stable at pace
- Cold water hose of entire body and limbs
- Ice boots applied for 20–30 minutes after hosing
- Electrolytes administered in post-race feed or water
- Report any veterinary concerns to racecourse veterinarian immediately
- If horse is swabbed: ensure Race-Day Treatment Declaration provided to stewards for any treatments given on raceday

9.3 Victoria Race-Day Compliance Rules

- **Race-Day Treatment Declaration:** Required for any medication or treatment administered on raceday
- **No analgesics or anti-inflammatory products** on raceday — including herbal formulations
- **Intra-articular injections:** prohibited within 8 clear days of race

- Any undeclared treatment = potential stewards inquiry and positive swab

PART 10: POST-RACE MANAGEMENT & PLANNING

10.1 Post-Race Assessment (Within 24–48 Hours)

Assessment	What to Check	Action if Abnormal
Limb palpation	Heat, swelling, pain response	Rest; veterinary assessment
Gait	Walk horse in hand; any irregularity	Veterinary lameness examination
Appetite	Eating normally within 12 hours?	Monitor; investigate if off feed >24 hours
Attitude	Bright and alert vs. dull?	Marked dullness requires veterinary check
Respiratory recovery	Should be at resting rate within 1 hour post-race	Slow recovery may indicate cardiac or respiratory issue
Epistaxis (EIPH)	Post-race bleed from one or both nostrils	Endoscope to grade; report to Racing Victoria veterinarian

10.2 Return-to-Work Options

Option A — Racing Again in 2–3 Weeks:
- Days 1–3: Rest; light walking only
- Days 4–7: Slow canter work (Phase 3 level intensity)
- Days 8–14: Return to ¾ pace and gallop work
- Days 14–18: Pre-race sharpening gallop → second race start

Option B — Short Spell (4–6 Weeks):
- Weeks 1–2: Paddock rest
- Week 3: Begin Pre-Training Phase 2
- Weeks 4–6: Compressed preparation (horse retains substantial base fitness)
- Total turnaround: 6–8 weeks

Option C — Full Spell (8+ Weeks):
- Follow the complete Phase 1–5 program from scratch
- Required after injury, significant illness, or when horse has had a demanding campaign

10.3 Campaign Planning for 1,200–1,400m Horses

- Most Victorian sprint/middle-distance horses race 10–15 times per year
- Optimal campaign: 4–8 race starts before a spell
- Horses typically improve race craft through their first 3–5 career starts — expect progressive improvement
- Form pattern analysis: if a horse consistently improves second or third start off a spell, plan training to arrive at peak fitness for those runs, not the first-up run

PART 11: COMPLIANCE CHECKLIST

Before Every Race

- [ ] No prohibited substances administered — all supplements verified against current ARR Schedule 1
- [ ] Last intra-articular injection was >8 clear days before race date
- [ ] Vaccination records current and available for racecourse inspection
- [ ] Trainer licence current with Racing Victoria
- [ ] Track rider has current Mandatory Trackwork Rider Accreditation
- [ ] Race-Day Treatment Declaration prepared (for any raceday treatment given)
- [ ] Horse has completed a steward-observed barrier trial or jump-out
- [ ] Horse has passed pre-race veterinary inspection on raceday
- [ ] All gear changes declared to stewards

Ongoing TRWP Compliance (Effective 1 May 2024)

- [ ] Stable/property passes Racing Victoria inspection standards
- [ ] Horses have unrestricted access to fresh water at all times
- [ ] Adequate forage provided daily (minimum TRWP guidelines)
- [ ] Horses are not confined without movement for extended periods without veterinary justification
- [ ] End-of-career plan documented for each horse in the stable
- [ ] Medication records maintained: substance, dose, date, administering veterinarian's details

Annual Checklist

- [ ] Trainer licence renewed with Racing Victoria
- [ ] Stable property inspection satisfactorily completed
- [ ] All horses: annual dental examination
- [ ] All horses: tetanus booster administered
- [ ] All horses: strangles vaccination (6-monthly schedule maintained)
- [ ] Fecal egg counts conducted; worming program current and documented
- [ ] Emergency veterinary contacts current and posted in stable

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SUMMARY — THE 14–16 WEEK TIMELINE AT A GLANCE

Week	Phase	Key Work	Speed Target	Admin/Vet
Spell (4–8 wks)	Paddock rest	Free grazing; no structured work	Walk only	Initial vet check; vaccinations if due
1–2	Pre-training	Walk + slow trot	Trot: 3.5–4.5 m/s	Dental check if due
3–4	Pre-training	Trot + slow canter	Canter: 5–7 m/s	Gradual hard feed reintroduction
5–6	Base fitness	Half-pace work begins	~11 m/s (40 km/h)	FEC / worming if needed
7–8	Base fitness	¾ pace + brush gallop	13–14 m/s (47–50 km/h)	Mid-prep blood panel
9–10	Race prep	Full gallops (5+2 program)	16–17 m/s (race pace)	Book barrier trial; pre-trial vet check
11–12	Race prep	Race-distance gallops	1,200m sustained work	Confirm racing entry
12–13	Pre-trial	Sharp gallops + BARRIER TRIAL	Trial honest, not over-extended	Confirm jockey, gear, declarations
13–14	Final prep	Sharpening gallop (Thursday)	Short, sharp piece	Confirm entry; RD Declaration if needed
14–16	RACE DAY	1,200–1,400m race	—	Post-race welfare assessment

PART 12: SOURCES & REFERENCES

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- Australian Rules of Racing — Racing Australia
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- Locomotory Profiles in Thoroughbreds — PMC (2022)
- Comparative Interval vs Conventional Training — ScienceDirect
- Basic Conditioning of the Equine Athlete — Extension Horses

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- MyRacehorse — Understanding Spelling Periods
- JRA Training Centers — Japan Racing Association
- The Equine Fitness Plan — Great British Racing

Nutrition:
- Virbac Australia — Feeding Thoroughbred Racehorses
- Kentucky Equine Research — Feeding Horses in Australia and New Zealand
- Foran Equine — Essential Supplements for Racehorses
- Ranvet — Feeding and Nutrition for the High Performance Racehorse
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- PMC — Consensus for Equine Water Treadmill Use (2021)
- ResearchGate — Swimming and Race Performance in Thoroughbreds
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- Merck Veterinary Manual — Vaccination Program for Horses
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Prepared June 2026. All regulatory information must be verified against current Racing Victoria and Racing Australia publications before implementation. This document is for educational and informational purposes and does not constitute professional training, veterinary, or legal advice.